THE NEXT 100 SPORTS

TOP SHOT

PAYAS JAIN, 17

Table tennis player, **New Delhi**

"He's got a very good technique and plays a daredevil game. If he can maintain his aggression, he will be one of the best India has ever produced"

SHARATH KAMAL ACHANTA
Nine-time national TT champion

Payas Jain was destined to play table tennis even if he didn't take a liking to the sport early on. "It was my parents' plan all along," says Jain, whose father Jitendra and mother Shweta, both former players, run the Table Tennis Foundation Academy in New Delhi. It is here that Payas has blossomed into one of India's most promising paddlers. Among his feats is a world no. 1 rank in the under-17 boys' singles category and a bronze in the under-19 category at the 2021 World Youth Championships in Portugal.

Jain symbolises the new-age Indian athlete who knows what it takes to be on top of the game. He does SPARQ (Speed, Power, Agility, Reaction and Quickness) training and uses high-tech strobe glasses to enhance neuromuscular efficiency and devise methods to beat the dominant Chinese. "The game is evolving; it has become very fast. There are many new techniques now," says Jain. "You have to strategise [even] in between the game."

Jain is known for his on-court speed, playing close to the table, strong backhand and ability to generate spin. His recent inclusion in the Sports Authority of India's Target Olympic Podium Scheme development group for the 2024 Olympics only shows how he is seen as a bright star of the game. ■

–Suhani Singh



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

FIGHTING FIT In 2020, Jain lost 18 kilos playing and training during the pandemic. He attributes his stellar showing in 2021, which includes three international titles, to his fitness.